

BURIED CHARMS AND BORROWED SIGNS

folk magic in North America



▲ Sator Square amulet

This early Christian magical tool called the Sator Square shows words that are readable backward or forward. In his book on pow-wows, Johann George Hohman stated that the Sator Square possessed properties that could extinguish fires as readily as protect cows from witches.

From the late 17th century, as wave upon wave of people arrived in North America, folk magic spread across the continent. Magical practices took three different forms: the activities of the cunning folk among English settlers; a variant, practiced by those known as “conjurers,” among African Americans; and a Germanic folk magic practiced by the people known as the Pennsylvania Dutch.

As in England, the cunning folk in North America were generally benevolent in their intentions—their concern was the well-being of their fellow settlers. To this end, they used a mixture of spells, herbal remedies, and various prized objects—amulets and written charms in particular, many buried for extra potency—to bring good fortune and to ward off evil.

► Miracles and magical symbols

This illustration from the 18th-century *Sixth and Seventh Books of Moses* of a man with a sword contains magical Israelite symbols. An inspiration for Hohman’s book *Pow-Wows*, the *Books* were a part-magical, part-religious confection of Hebrew, Roman, and Christian sources and related how, among other biblical miracles, Moses turned his staff into a snake and conjured a pillar of fire.

From cunning folk to conjurers

If not explicitly Christian, cunning folk still evoked the name of Christ for protection. There remained a popular, superstitious belief in the malign that needed to be guarded against, and not just among the freeborn English settlers. The cunning folk were mirrored by those among the African American population similarly thought to possess magical gifts. They, too, believed in burying objects charged with magical significance. At Ferry Farm, George Washington’s Virginia childhood home, in an example of ritual placement, oysters were embedded in the foundations in the hope of safeguarding the house and its inhabitants.

However, there was a crucial distinction between conjurers and cunning folk: the former were enslaved people who, like hundreds of thousands of others, had been forcibly transported to the New World. The conjurers’ role in helping their enslaved brothers and sisters acquired a poignant urgency.

